from practical. The Madras Agent of SSNCo claimed that sixteen Japanese officers had been hired, and no Europeans would be engaged. But this is not borne out by facts. S.D. Krishna Aiyangar stated that he did not object to having European officers to begin with but that 'Indians should pick up management in course of time. I would like the Indians to take the sole management at the earliest possible moment.'[111] Highly paid, the loyalties of the European crew may also have wavered—but we have no information on this. Perforce, SSNCo had to rely on well-paid European sailors that added to the costs. In general, while 90 per cent of the crew was Indian and only 10 per cent European on ships that sailed in Indian waters, 'the total salary of the 10 per cent is [*sic*] practically equal to or [a] little less than the salary of the 90 per cent'.[112]

Handling the non-Indian crew was neither easy nor simple. SSNCo depended on them for purchase of coal and the company, 'had to work only with them and through their help'.[113] The challenge was to learn their 'trickeries' as S.D. Krishna Aiyangar described it: '… Indians should *find out* the tricks employed by officers and they should be able to check the malpractices of the subordinate officials, in the matter of the purchase of coal, provisions, etc.'[114] Thus he wanted Indians to learn the whole business: office management, the trading side and navigation. Lack of experience was an issue, but the company soldiered on. 'Wherever we found we were losing, we were able to trace it out and close the loophole,' recalled S.D. Krishna Aiyangar later.[115]

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William W. Chapman, engaged as captain of the *Gallia* on 28 February 1907, was no stranger to Colombo as he had recently been in command of the *William*. Born in Liverpool in 1861, Chapman had acquired his competency certification in 1888 from South Shields and was an experienced sailor with nearly twenty years of sailing behind him. A police report of 2 June 1907 stated that SSNCo had dismissed Chapman, on charges of misconduct.[116] We have no further details but the Lloyd's